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NOTES FROM THE SOUTH

Bhilwara Sur Sangam breaks new ground with a veena concert **P2**

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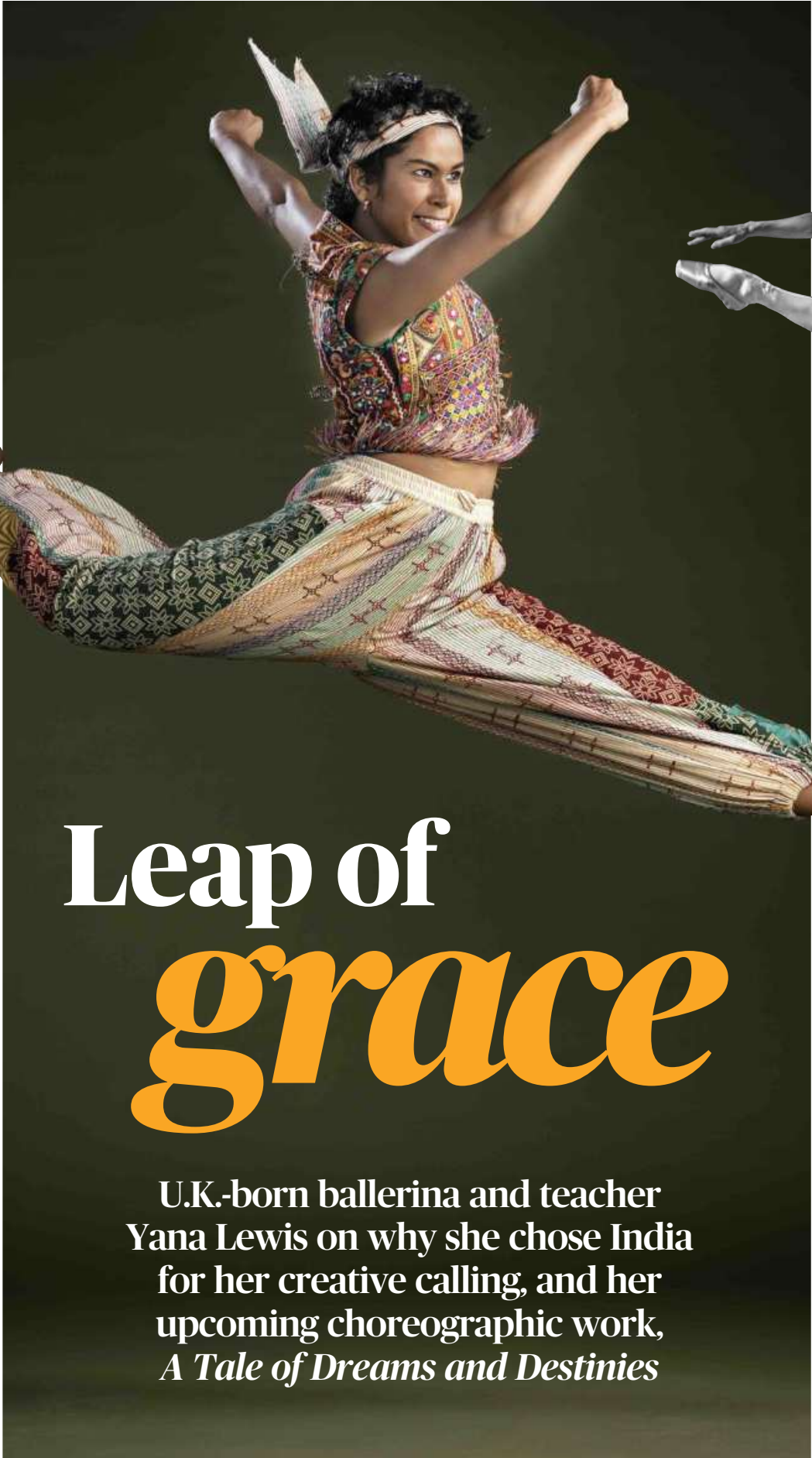
It's a warm afternoon, and Shoonya on Lalbagh Road in Bengaluru is teeming with dancers prepping for an intense rehearsal session. They belong to The Lewis Foundation of Classical Ballet, which is gearing up to stage its new production, 'A Tale of Dreams and Destinies'. The dancers quickly change into ballet tights and leotards. When they launch into movements what you see are sculpted frames, graceful lines and gentle leaps.

Petite, yet commanding, the U.K.-born Yana Lewis orchestrates the 200-odd dancers with a voice that cuts through the chatter. "This is our seventh in-house production, based on a classic tale from *One Thousand and One Nights*," she says, leading us into the main dance hall. Yana calls out a few last-minute instructions; latecomers scamper into place, the music begins and the ballet unfolds.

Yana wants to open the show with a *port de bras* set to 'Vande Mataram' as a homage to the country that has been her home for the past 28 years.

A Tale of Dreams and Destinies is about a thief who discovers a magical lamp and a princess yearning to see the world beyond her palace walls. Their paths converge, and together they face obstacles that test their resolve and lead them toward a shared destiny. "At its core, the story celebrates the power of dreams and the courage to make them real – whether you are a thief, a princess, a vizier, maharaja, djinn, or simply a passerby in the wondrous city of Khazaanagarh," explains Yana.

Dancers glide through arabesques (one of ballet's most iconic positions) and jetés (a leap where the dancer throws one leg into the air and jumps from one foot to the other). Their *port de bras* remains fluid, yet precise. Ballet formations create sweeping patterns, while solos soar in a grand allegro. Each leap and plié carries a narrative weight, tracing the character's journey with elegance, leaving you awestruck that India can shape ballet of extraordinary grace, as more people embrace this Western art with conviction.



Leap of grace

U.K.-born ballerina and teacher Yana Lewis on why she chose India for her creative calling, and her upcoming choreographic work, *A Tale of Dreams and Destinies*

In India, where dance is often grounded, ballet arrives as something otherworldly. Its language is one of elevation, where the form defies gravity. A western dance style, ballet is now becoming a bridge – a dialogue between cultures.

After an hour, Yana announces a break to talk about why she chose to pursue this dance style, that too in India. The challenges she faced in setting up her school, her training methodology and choreographic works.

Managing dancers in India means "navigating the endless cycle of exams," Yana states. "Students juggle academics and art, often stepping away from rehearsals. Yet there are

a few in higher grades that manage both, finding dance to sharpen their focus." Passion, she insists, must coexist with education. "Wake up at 3 a.m., study, then dance – it's possible," she says, embodying her own philosophy of discipline, waking up at 4 a.m. daily.

About her early days as a teacher, Yana shares: "In India, young girls would watch *Barbie* or the *Nutcracker* and come to me to learn ballet. Parents too would bring them without really understanding the dance themselves, so we had open classes to educate them. Today, children understand our storytelling easier. When I performed at

NCPA, Mumbai, I also conducted a workshop for Indian classical dancers, showing them the similarities between the two forms. The external rotation of the legs, the use of the foot, the lifting versus grounding and so on. If you train both sets of muscles, they complement each other. Later, I taught ballet to Indian classical dancer Rukmini Vijayakumar, who went on to study at Boston Conservatoire. She said ballet took her Bharatanatyam to another level. Ballet opens a whole new world. It changes the aesthetic but not the style, making jumps and lifts easier."



Ballet beckons (Clockwise from left) Yana Lewis; and students of The Lewis Foundation Tejas Parmesh; Krita Yernool and Maya Haridas. PHOTOS COURTESY: THE LEWIS FOUNDATION OF CLASSICAL BALLET



Yana does not "perform anymore. I'm 64. Now I teach and have collaborated with Indian classical dancers too. I enjoy working with gurus who work without prejudice. I find it enriching. There's always learning – you never stop if you're a real artiste." Yana also speaks candidly about the diet of ballet dancers: "food must be fuel for the body. Fruits, nuts and light food sustains energy, while heavy meals hinder performance. "You can't dance on rice and dal – it just sits in your tummy," she says, encouraging healthier choices in classes for rigorous rehearsals.

Yana started learning ballet at the age of two. "I told my mother I wanted to be a butterfly. She interpreted that as my desire to fly and took me to ballet class – and that's where it all began," says Yana who is inspired by Sylvie Guillem. "The top-ranking French dancer brought an avant-garde style to ballet that was beyond that era, and diverse movement-based nuances," adds Yana, who strongly believes a career in dance is possible. "You have to be adventurous and take that leap and see where the journey takes you."

Yana's daughter now trains abroad, having attended the Royal Ballet School and Australian Ballet Company programmes.

Yana shares that her students too have gone overseas – Boston Conservatoire, London schools, University of North Carolina. And now, she hopes to open a full-time vocational ballet school in India.

Her journey has also crossed borders through collaborations with a Swiss dance company, where Yana "blended European precision with expressive style". She has performed for television in the U.K. and toured with companies before yoga brought her to India in 1998. After living in Mumbai, she settled in Bengaluru to start a ballet school, "keeping my promise to dancers I had met along the way that I would return to teach".

Yana launched the Lewis Foundation of Classical Ballet in 2006. Her main studio is in Ulsoor, with centres in Koramangala, Kalyan Nagar, J.P. Nagar and Whitefield. "Younger graders train at centres, while higher graders train at Ulsoor. I visit the centres, ensuring everyone gets my attention."

According to Yana, it has been a wonderful journey, but a challenging one. "Carving out a space for yourself in a country with a thriving classical arts scene calls for commitment and perseverance. Initially, the school did not attract many students, but over the years it has grown to become one of India's distinct ballet companies. Despite the hesitancy around the rigour of training, I do not compromise on ballet values. This approach has helped me build a well-trained set of dancers, with whom I have gone on to create choreographic works such as *Alice*, *Sleeping Beauty*, *Cinderella* and modern pieces such as *Oz* and *Alice*."

For her, *A Tale of Dreams and Destinies* is deeply tied to the present. "The world feels uncertain, full of instability. It is scary. I think this show is about dreams and following through with your belief system. Passion is something that can't be changed, not even by AI. Someone asked me if AI could do my job, and I said absolutely not. It can produce a show, but it won't be an imagined or creative piece."

A Tale of Dreams and Destinies will be staged on April 12, 12:30 p.m. and 5:30 p.m., at Prestige Centre for Performing Arts, Bengaluru.

Adishakti gears up for the 12th edition of the 'Remembering Veenapani Festival' (RVF) – a nine-day celebration of the life and legacy of its founder Veenapani Chawla.

To be held between April 12 and 20, the festival will bring together a series of theatre and music performances.

RVF began in 2015, a year after Veenapani Chawla's passing, as an organic response from artists and admirers determined to keep her creative spirit alive. Over the years, it has grown into one of India's most-anticipated performing arts festivals, drawing artists from across the world who perform not for profit but for the love of the space and the community it nurtures. Adishakti, located on a lush three-acre campus near Auroville, was founded in 1981 by Veenapani and

remains a close-knit collective led today by artistic director Vinay Kumar and managing trustee Nimmy Raphael.

The festival was first held in April 2015 during the founder's birth month, and has continued annually except for a two-year pause during the pandemic. "With every edition, it is not just the performances that take centre

stage, but the conversations that resonate beyond Puducherry, reaching and inspiring other creative communities," says Vinay. Nimmy adds, "Our location, surrounded by four villages in Tamil Nadu, is central to our vision. This is why we keep our performances non-ticketed. The enthusiastic attendance at every event reaffirms the importance of

In line with a vision

Adishakti to host the 12th edition of the Remembering Veenapani Festival



Art for art's sake
Veenapani Chawla.

this approach."

The 2026 edition opens on April 12 with 'Mone Rekho' (Remember), a sarod recital by Soumik Datta, accompanied by Debjit Patitundi on tabla. It is produced in partnership with international institutions and supported by Arts Council England and others.

On April 13, 'Sage for the Ages' – a genre-fluid quartet blending voice, guitar, keys, bass and drums – will launch its album 'R-Evolution'.

April 14 features 'Rubber Girl', conceptualised and performed by Preethi Athreya.

April 15 brings Bob Marley from Kodihalli by Jangama Collective – a cluster of stories on identity and

discrimination.

April 16 presents 'The Queen' by 72° East Production, directed by Daniel Owen Dsouza, followed on April 17 by Adishakti's 'A Woman or Not To Be', written and directed by Vinay Kumar.

On April 18, 'Something Like Truth' – written by Shanta Gokhale and directed by Parna Pethe, explores freedom and justice through four monologues.

April 19 showcases Shudraka's 'Mrchakatikam' by Natanakairali, directed by G. Venu, with a large ensemble cast led by Kapila Venu.

The festival concludes on April 20 with Electronic Folk Music by the Vasu Dixit Collective, blending tradition and innovation.

All events will be held at Adishakti, beginning at 7.30 p.m. everyday, except the inaugural concert which starts at 7 p.m.



Shailaja Khanna

Among the many festivals across the country that celebrate the richness of Indian classical arts, the Bhilwara Sur Sangam occupies a special place. The annual two-day festival, held recently in Delhi, began with a vocal concert of Bhagyesh Marathe, the grandson of legendary vocalist Pt. Ram Marathe. Bhagyesh, among top-ranking young musicians, impressed with his pliant voice.

The evening concluded with a Saraswathi veena concert by Jayanthi Kumaresh. This marked the debut of the veena at the festival, and only the second occasion in its 13-year history that a



Carnatic musician was invited. Hence, there were mixed expectations. But Jayanthi never disappoints. She held the audience's attention throughout the

concert. The centrepiece of her performance was an hour's delineation of raga Behag, which she embellished with some rarely heard and awe-inspiring phrases.

Musical melange (From left) Jayanthi Kumaresh; Samanvay Sarkar with Pt. Ram Kumar Mishra; and Pt. Mukul Shivputra with Mithilesh Jha and Vinay Mishra. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



She matches her impeccable technique with a perfect choice of ragas. Jayanthi ended her concert with a thumri 'Baat chala' in Bhairavi (Sindhu Bhairavi in the Carnatic idiom).

The concluding evening commenced with a sitar recital by Samanvay Sarkar from Kolkata. Not heard on the concert platform as much as he should be, given his expertise, Samanvay boasts an eclectic training, including learning the sitar from Pt. Manilal Nag of the Vishnupur gharana, and spending a decade learning the nuances of vocal music from vidushi Girija Devi.

Samanvay opened his concert with an exploration of raag Shuddha Kalyan, presenting a comprehensive alaap and jor. The meend work on the kharaj strings was noteworthy, while the gamaks and bolkaari were handled with a judicious sense of timing. The three compositions he played were in Teen taal – two were khayals that he converted into instrumental compositions. He was accompanied by Pt. Ram Kumar Mishra, a distinguished exponent of the Benaras gharana. Samanvay concluded with a 'tappa' in raag Kafi.

Pt. Mukul Shivputra's concert made for a grand finale. Despite an interval, the blasé Delhi audience

stayed on, unwilling to miss this reclusive musician's performance. Mukul, who is not often seen on the concert circuits, was featured at this festival a few years ago as well, which remains a memorable moment.

Mukul chose raag Basant as the main piece. Today not many musicians attempt a full-fledged exploration of the raag, fearing it might veer into allied raags. So, listeners have become accustomed to hearing shorter versions, or being paired with other raags such as Basant Bahar or Paraj Basant. Both his compositions – in Teen taal were traditional, yet rarely heard, with the concluding tarana being a favourite of his father, Pt. Kumar Gandharva. He then sang a thumri in Khamach, 'Kaise bajavat bansuriya', which tugged at the heartstrings. He sought to conclude with a bhajan, but the audience would not let him. So, after a brief interval, he concluded with a delightful Bhairavi.

Mukul's music is hard to be assessed by conventional yardsticks. His frail appearance belies the strength of his music. Since he understands sound well, he deliberately kept the amplification low to enhance the aural experience. He was accompanied by Mithilesh Jha on the tabla, who was a bit intrusive and loud. On the harmonium was Vinay Mishra, who sustained the mood created by the vocalist.

CALENDAR

Dance and discourse

The Music Academy will feature the following events at Kasturi Srinivasan Hall.

Today, 6 p.m.: Vignesh Chandrasekharan's harikatha with Palakkad G. Kailasapathy on the violin and Sriram Srinivasan on the mridangam. The programme is organised under the endowment, instituted by Sri Maruthi Bhakta Samajam Trust, in memory of Srirangam V.S. Venkataramana Rao.

April 16, 6 p.m.: Nanda Kishore's Bharatanatyam recital as part of HCL concert series.



Solo margam

Sridevi Nrithyalaya presents the second edition of Kriya on April 13, 6.30 p.m. at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Mylapore. The evening will feature the solo Bharatanatyam recital of Bhairavi Venkatesan, one of the seniormost disciples of Sheela Unnikrishnan.

Bhairavi will be presenting a self-choreographed margam featuring the compositions of the Thanjavur Quartet.

K.N. Ramaswamy, director, Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, will preside. Senior Bharatanatyam dancer Priyadarsini Govind will be the chief guest.

Voices beyond boundaries

Art Unfettered 2026, presented by the Sumanasa Foundation, will be held April 12 and 13 at the M.S. Subbulakshmi Auditorium, Asian College of Journalism, Chennai. The two-day event marks the culmination of its Grants Project 2025-26 - showcasing five grantees whose practices span across theatre, visual art, music and interdisciplinary explorations.

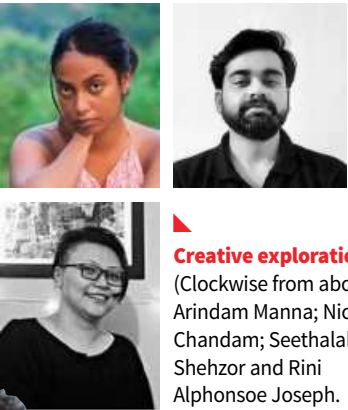
The grantees are: Nicky Chandam, a story-seeker exploring narratives through photography, writing and oral storytelling. As the founder of Octave Foundation, she advocates for accessible mental health services while celebrating cultural diversity.

Shehzor, a rapper-poet and producer from Hyderabad, has travelled across India since 2022, immersing herself in hip-hop, lokgeet, and qawwali, while creating with her band - Inshallah Babes - an album reflecting trans-queer realities.

Seethalakshmi Neelagandan, pursuing a PhD in Social Work and



Mental Health, brings her research on non-normative genders into art, moving from puppetry to theatre in works like Maaya Maram. Rini Alphonsa Joseph, artist and potter, channels Adivasi and sea folk ancestry to craft narratives of



Creative explorations (Clockwise from above) Arindam Manna; Nicky Chandam; Seethalakshmi; Shehzor and Rini Alphonsoe Joseph.



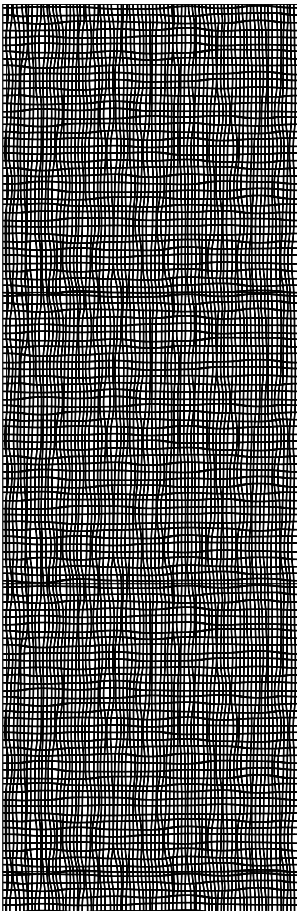
memory and transformation. From West Bengal, Arindam Manna investigates place, movement and memory through painting, photography and installation, tracing landscapes shaped by migration and time. Together, their works form a festival of resilience, imagination and unfettered creativity.

Bhajan clubbing

ISKCON, Chennai, will launch Bhajan Clubbing, a devotional event for youth, on April 14, from 5 p.m. to 8 pm at the ISKCON Temple Marriage Hall.

Aimed at those aged between 16 and 30, the programme reimagines traditional kirtan in a concert-style format that brings together live devotional music with both Western and traditional Indian instruments, including guitar, bass, violin, flute, mridangam, kartal, and pads.

Register at <https://wame.pro/BhajanClubbing>.



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